



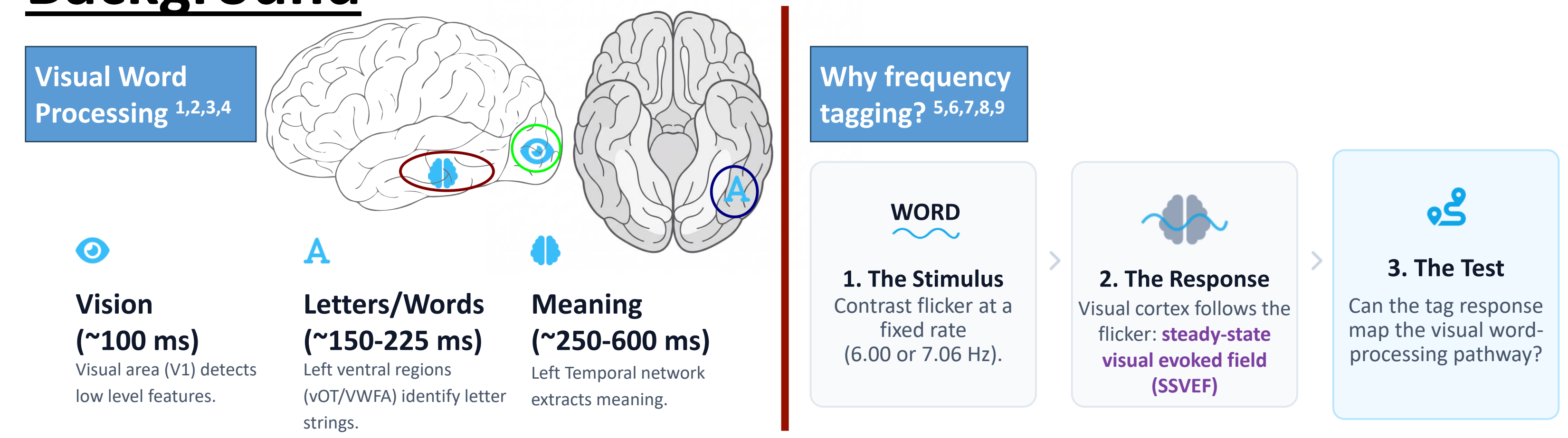
Characterizing word processing pathway using frequency tagging

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A **6 / 7.06 Hz flicker tag** tracks the visual input, not wordness; the **word-locked response** (250–600 ms) separates words from consonant strings, and in anterior temporal cortex the difference is sustained across words.

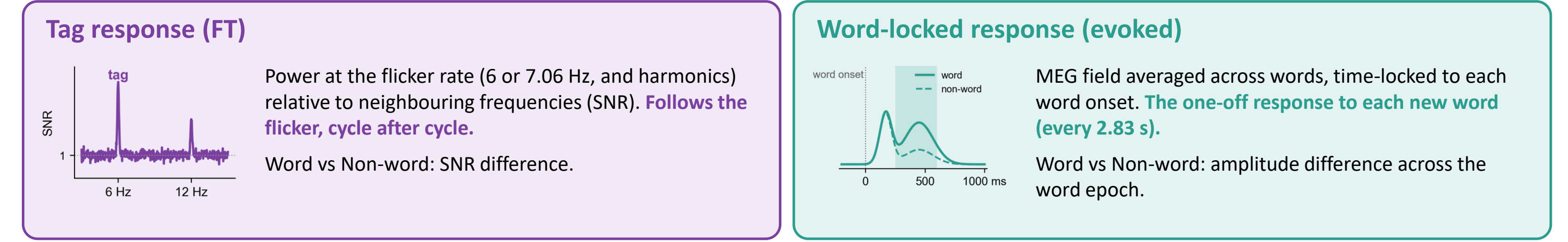
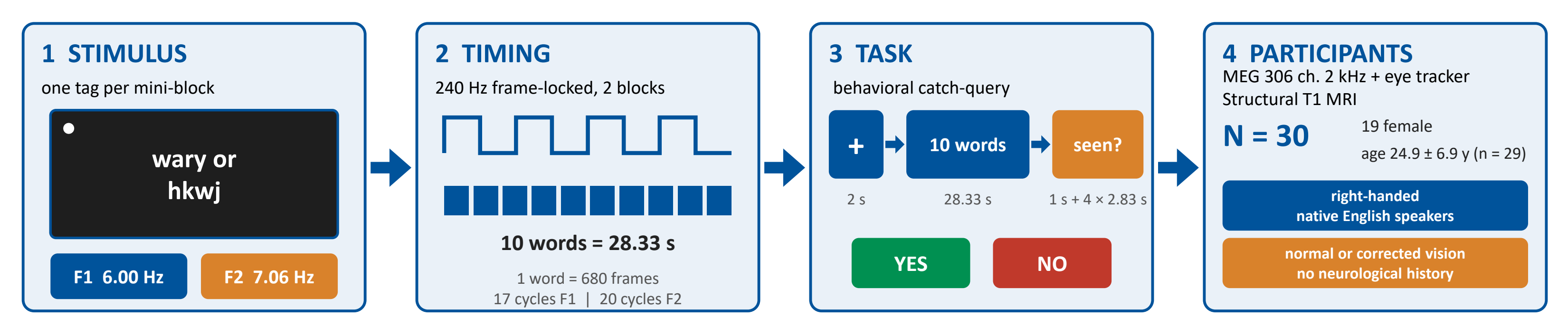
Update vs. submitted abstract: with fixation baselines and equal trial counts, the tag shows no word-specific effect and the source effect is Word > Non-word.

Background



- AIM 1**
Do MEG sensors and sources recover the V1 → vOT → temporal sequence of the literature?
- AIM 2**
Does the tag response (SSVEF) differ between words and consonant strings?

Methods



Pitfalls we hit — and how we fixed them

- Tags off by one FFT bin.** The display ran ~0.5 % slow (photodiode: 5.965 / 7.024 Hz): read the SNR at the measured bin.
- Unequal trial counts faked an effect.** A time-resolved source effect vanished once counts were equalized (the whole-epoch effect remains).
- No gap between words.** The pre-stimulus window holds the previous word: baseline on fixation instead.
- Check the noise-covariance rank.** After SSS, 3 subjects kept a ~1e-38 eigenvalue (dSPM × 10⁶, distorted maps): fixed with `mne.compute_rank(tol='auto')`.



Code · supplementary figures S1–S4 · cohort
github.com/Orion212-lab/snl2026-ft-word-pathway

Cohort 30 recorded; each panel states its N. Excluded: no flicker on the photodiode, malformed blocks, all epochs rejected; sources: no T1 MRI, artifact (sub-20/24). Kept with trigger anomalies: sub-10–14 (main results unchanged without them). List via QR.

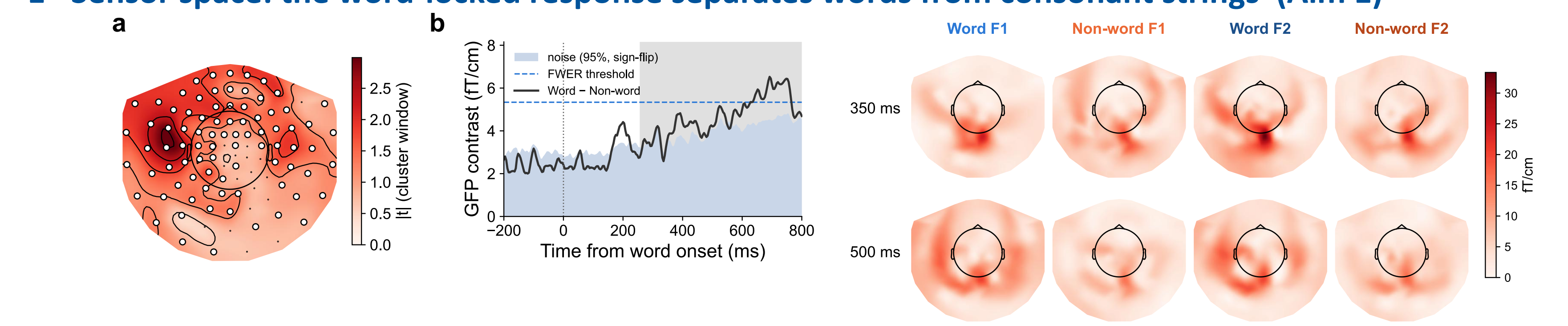
A priori Word vs Non-word at the tag and in the evoked cascade windows (80–130, 150–225, 250–600 ms), left-temporal sensors. Not preregistered; everything else is exploratory.

Limits consonant strings differ in orthography, pronounceability, visual complexity, difficulty · condition-pure blocks · late vOT fragile · localizer, catch-query accuracy not yet analysed

Next pseudowords · item-rate (FPVS) tagging instead of contrast flicker · interleaved conditions · two-word phrase task (intermodulation), recorded, not yet analysed

Results

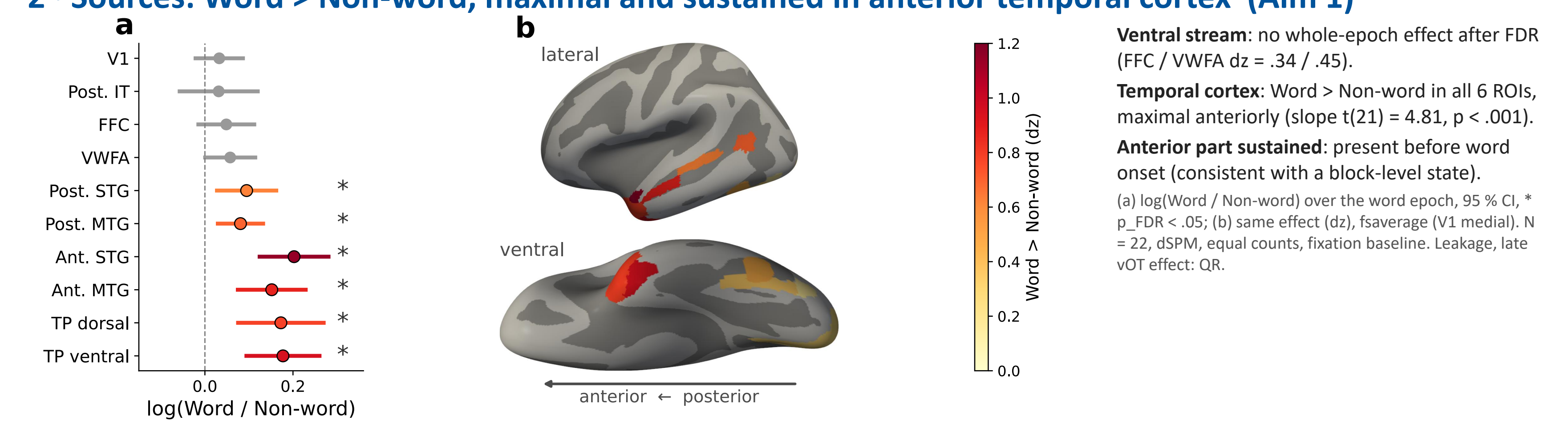
1 · Sensor space: the word-locked response separates words from consonant strings (Aim 1)



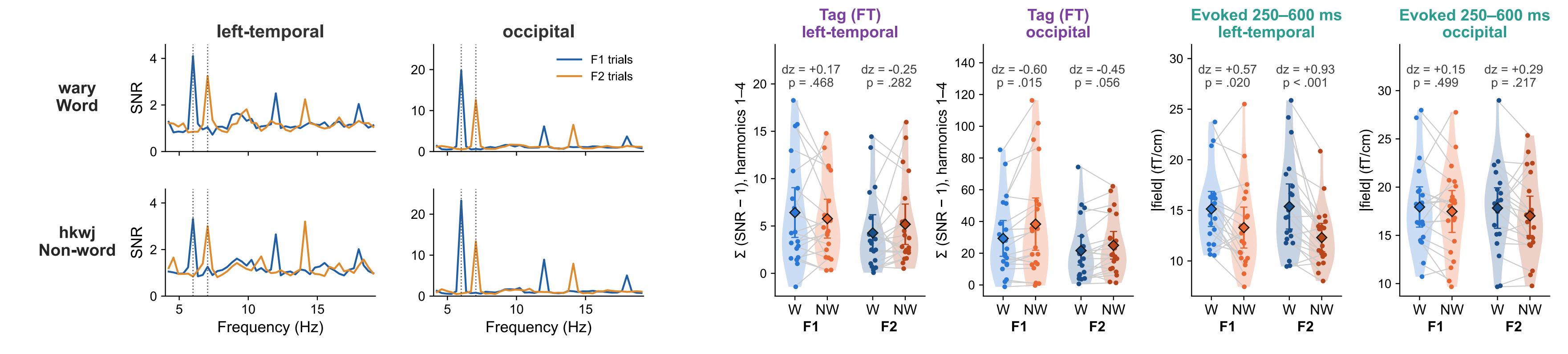
One Word > Non-word cluster over left posterior and temporal sensors (N = 26, 84 sensors, $p < .001$), robust to blinks, saccades and artifacts (clean epochs: $dz = 1.31$, 20/21 subjects). Tag × Wordness: n.s.

(a) mean |t| in the cluster window (N = 26); (b) GFP of W – NW vs sign-flip noise (shaded: 95 %; dashed: FWER), exceeded at 628–764 ms; right: grand averages (N = 25) at 350 / 500 ms, ±25 ms; fixation baseline.

2 · Sources: Word > Non-word, maximal and sustained in anterior temporal cortex (Aim 1)



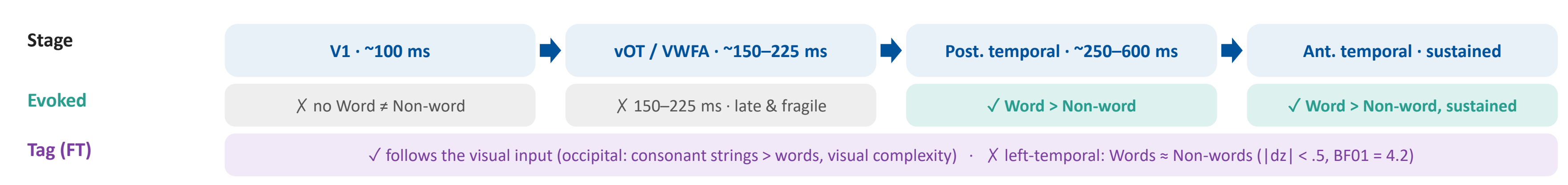
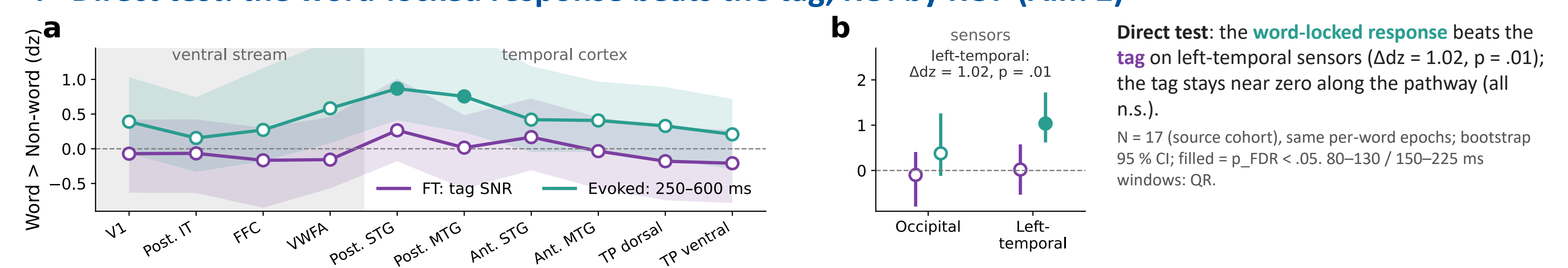
3 · The tag follows the visual input, not wordness (Aim 2)



Tag (harmonics 1–4): occipital Non-words > Words ($dz = -.88$, $p < .001$), following their extra ink; left-temporal Words ≈ Non-words ($|dz| < .5$, TOST $p = .03$, $BF01 = 4.2$). **Evoked** 250–600 ms, the reverse: left-temporal W > NW ($dz = 1.04$, $p < .001$), occipital n.s.

N = 20 (sensor cohort), same epochs for both measures; per-word SNR, 2.83 s F1, 3 neighbours/side; diamonds = mean ± 95 % CI; Tag × Wordness n.s.

4 · Direct test: the word-locked response beats the tag, ROI by ROI (Aim 2)



Aim 1 — partly: temporal stages replicated, vOT only late and fragile, latency order n.s. **Aim 2 — no:** the tag indexes visual input, not wordness; the word-locked response does.

References

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